

Fishing for Sustainability — Round 1

Open-Access Fishing

Name: _____

Goal

Experience how individual self-interest can deplete a shared resource when there are **no regulations**.

Materials (Instructor provides)

- 1 bowl = **lake** (starts with **30 fish**: candies/beans/tokens)
- 8 cups = **boats** (one per student)

Biological Rule

After harvest, fish remaining in the lake **double** (up to a **maximum of 30**).

Communication Rules (Read aloud & follow exactly)

- **Do NOT** talk, signal, make eye contact, or coordinate in any way.
- **You are independent fishers.** No communication is permitted **until after** this hand-out is collected.

 You may communicate:

Nothing at all. No talking, signaling, or writing to each other.

Procedure

1. **Secret Choice (0–6):** Privately decide how many fish to take (0–6). Write the number on your paper; **do not show** anyone.
2. **Simultaneous Harvest:** When the instructor says “**Fish!**” everyone takes their chosen fish at the same time.
3. **If total fish taken > fish available:** The fishery **collapses** (0 fish remain). **Stop.**
4. **If fish remain:** Instructor counts the remaining fish, then **doubles** them (up to 30).
5. **Record** your results in the table below.

Data Table (Round 1)

Item	Value
Your catch	
Total class catch	
Fish remaining after harvest	
Fish after reproduction (doubled, max 30)	

Individual Reflection (submit with this handout)

1. Did you try to cooperate (take fewer) or maximize personal catch? Why?
2. Did you trust others to restrain themselves? Why or why not?
3. Predict how many **more** rounds this fishery could last under open access.
4. In one sentence, explain how Round 1 illustrates the **Tragedy of the Commons**.

Participation Check (instructor initials when reviewed)

- ☐ Data table filled
- ☐ Four reflection answers written

Stop here. Hand this sheet in. Wait quietly for the next handout.